

schemes and poaching disgruntled or opportunistic elements from Opposition parties serves this purpose. But there is more to his manoeuvres. His larger goal is to consolidate the powers of heir apparent Stalin. A weak Opposition has lesser chances of tormenting the chief minister-in-waiting in the Assembly. Karunanidhi had deputed Stalin to the chief ministers' conference held in Delhi recently. In the past, it was K. Anbazhagan, a senior leader and finance minister, who represented the state if the chief minister could not make it.

A stronger DMK is a scary sight to

Congress membership drive, which they think would eventually help top-ple bigger parties by replicating Rahul Gandhi's Uttar Pradesh model. The agony of Jayalalithaa, who never fails to add the "minority" adjective whenever she refers to the DMK Government, is even greater.

Clever strategist that he is, Karunanidhi may have a 'Plan B' to survive without the Congress's support. He can do it with the support of the PMK, CPI and CPI(M) which have 18, six and nine MLAs respectively in

probably use it only when he can no longer intimidate the Opposition or humiliate his ally.

Meanwhile, he continues to play peacemaker with his neighbours. On September 15, another chief minister from a neighbouring state, Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy of Andhra Pradesh, would come calling. He is being roped in as the chief guest for the centenary celebrations of DMK founder Anna Durai. Like the Cauvery river dispute with Karnataka, there are differences over the Palar river with Andhra Pradesh. Friendship with neighbours might



YEDDYURAPPA WITH KARUNANIDHI AT THE UNVEILING OF KANNADA POET SARVAGNAR'S STATUE IN CHENNAI

By courting Yeddyurappa, Karunanidhi shows he doesn't suffer from saffron-phobia.

the Congress. With 99 MLAs, the DMK needs 19 more to get an absolute majority. The state Congress leaders have already begun attacking its ungracious big partner for excluding them from the ministry. After the DMK-Congress sweep in the by-elections, Gnanarajasekaran, a Congress MLA, said: "The Central Government can be run even without the support of the DMK. But the DMK rule in Tamil Nadu cannot go on without the support of the Congress. If Sonia Gandhi utters one word, the DMK rule will collapse." The occasion was state Youth

the Assembly. Or he can call early elections before the end of his term in 2011 to ensure that he and his sons get a clear mandate. The last option looks more viable as the party desperately wants to discard the 'minority government' tag. Says a politician close to the DMK patriarch, "Karunanidhi is always nimble-footed in his thinking. Though his body has aged, his mind is still young. You can't predict whether he would exercise the mid-term poll option now, when there are two long years left for the next Assembly elections." He would

help Karunanidhi to break the deadlock on these issues. Party insiders say that Karunanidhi also has plans to go soft on Kerala—which too has a river dispute with Tamil Nadu—with an olive-branch invitation to Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan.

When Tamil Nadu goes Stalinist, the grand old man of Dravidian politics may want to redeem the word from its historical stigma. He may want peace on the borders and absolute majority in the Assembly on coronation day. That is why, even at 86, the *Thalaivar* cannot afford to relax. ■